Weinführer poured the heating oil into the vats so that he wouldn't be suspicious."

Léa sat down on a low stool.

He scratched his forehead and shrugged. "I guess you're not going back to the house?"

"I want to help you, the way André did."

"All right then." He sighed. "Let's get to work."

"What's down there?" Léa asked, pointing at an opening farther on.

"A tunnel that leads nearly to the river, a little over 500 meters. When I was a boy, my father used the tunnel to move the wine in barrels rather than going through town to reach the transport boats on the Loire. At one time, a train ran through Combleux."

Léa walked over to the tunnel, which had a thick layer of dust on the ground and cobwebs across the opening. "What's at the other end?" She tried to imagine a door, but to where?

"There's a metal ladder at the end, which you can climb to reach a metal hatch that opens to the outside. We keep it sealed to prevent flooding. That's why the tunnel doesn't go up to the river. Before the locks and canal were built, Combleux had its fair share of flooding."

She noticed a key hanging on the side wall and pointed to it. "What's it for?"

"It opens the metal hatch at the other end. I don't like going in there. The ceiling is low, and it gives me an uneasy feeling."

She could understand that and wouldn't want to go in there either. "What can I help you with?"

"I need to put the labels on the demijohns. If you can cut them off the printed sheets," he said, motioning to paper on the ground under the stairs, "then I'll show you how to stick them on with a brush of water."

Léa smiled. "Yes, I can do that."

He brought the labels out from under the stairs and handed them to her. At the top was printed *Édouard LeBlanc*, and below it a cluster of grapes hanging from a vine, followed by *1942*, and the grape variety, *Sauvignon Blanc*. Léa settled on the ground and began cutting through the open spaces between the squares with scissors.

"Make sure you cut off my name. Only leave the year and the grape variety."